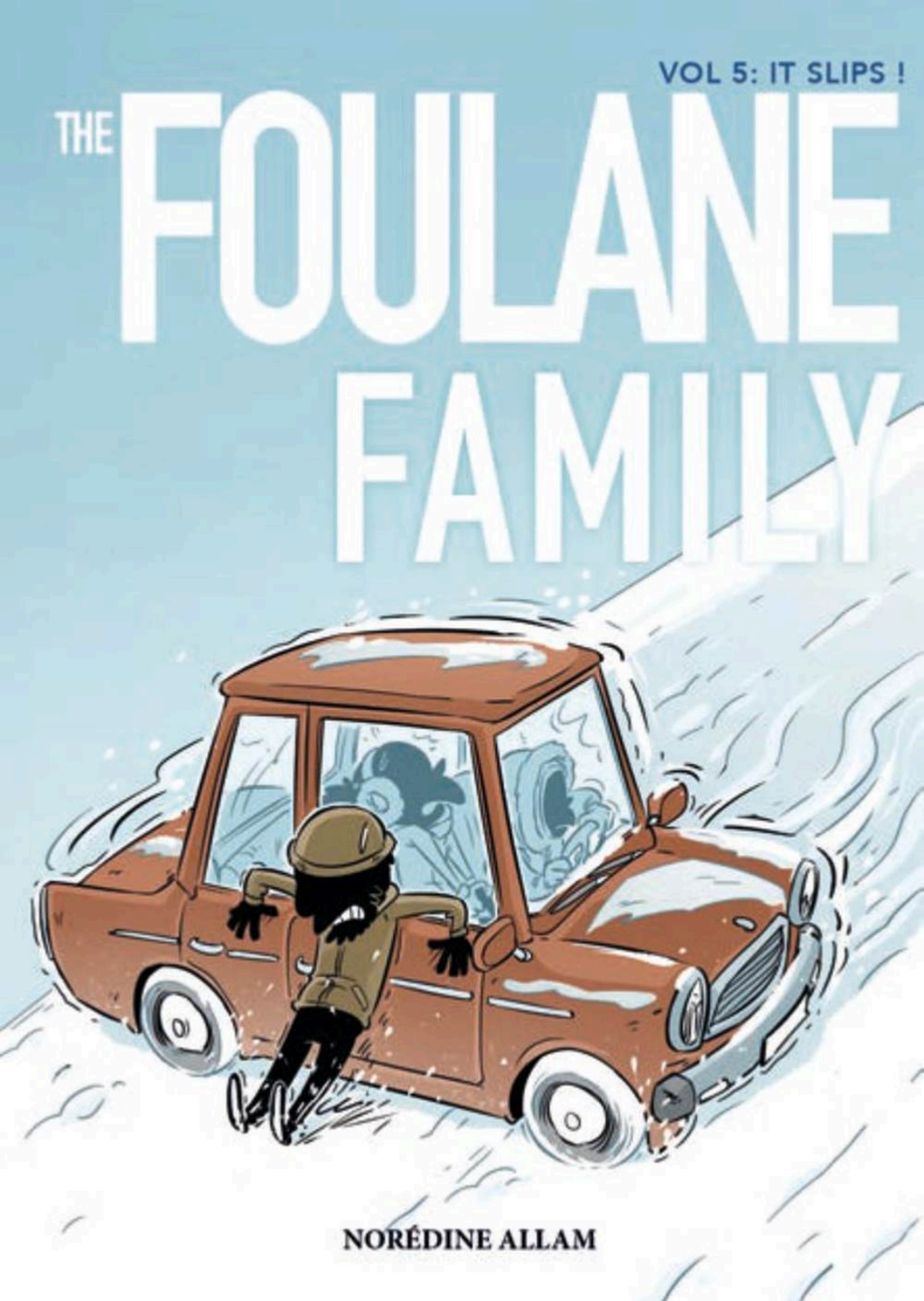
VOL 5: IT SLIPS !

THE FOULANE FAMILY



NORÉDINE ALLAM

THE FOULANE FAMILY

Vol 5. It slips!

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The Foulane Family

Vol.5

It slips!

By Norédine Allam.

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1. Thumb

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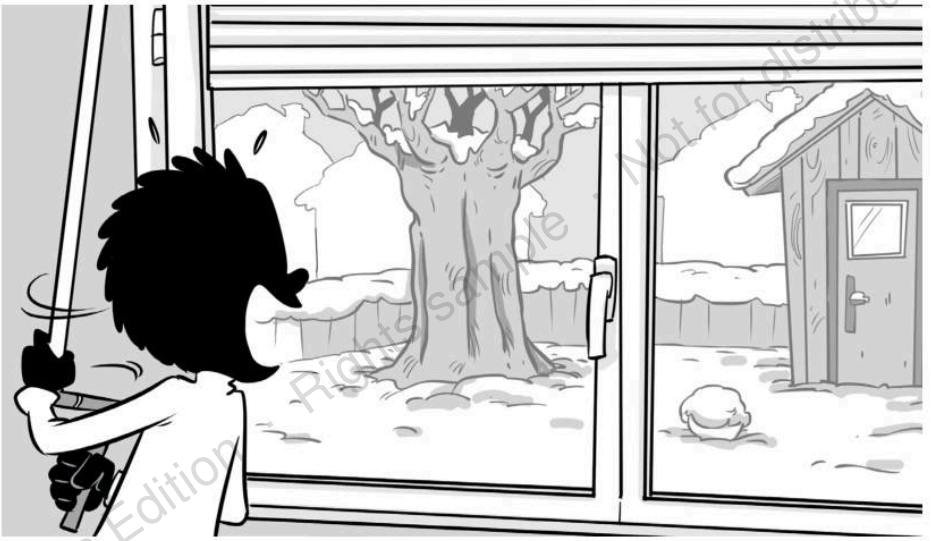
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The first flakes of snow had fallen in the night. Last night, Binti had predicted that this would happen. She's got a nose for it.

Snow usually arrives earlier at the start of the year. But as Abi often says: 'There are no more seasons.'

And even though it was Binti who sensed it, I was the first one to see it when I opened the blinds this morning.

"BINTIIII!! There's snow outside! The whole garden's covered! Masha'Allah!!"



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After checking for herself, Binti ran to the front door to be the first to touch it.

"Where are you going?" intervened Oummi, standing in front of the door.

"I just wanted to check if it was powder or hard snow."

"Well, you can check all that after breakfast and, incidentally, after you've cleared the table, brushed your teeth, packed your school gear and put your coat on!"

That's about twenty-five minutes of intensive activity.

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The reason Binti was so keen to know whether it was powder or not was because she knew that if it is powder, then it's impossible to have snow ball fights or build igloos with it.

And we like hard snow! Ha ha.

At the table, Oummi reminded us of the rules to follow when it snows. She had remembered the problems of previous years and was determined to avoid them!

"Walad, you go out with your boots on! And don't run on the pavement until you're sure it's not slippery." She added "And don't walk around the house with your socks all wet! And you, Binti, keep your ear muffs OVER your ears! Is that clear?"

After we had agreed to all of Oummi's conditions, me and Binti threw our clothes on as fast as we could and ran outside to finally test out this famous snow!

While Binti hesitated a little before stepping outside, I took a leap worthy of the greatest athletes!



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“Be careful, Mr Stuntman!” lectured Binti. “Oummi said we had to be careful.”

“Oh come on, we can have a laugh!”

“So, what’s the situation. How does the snow feel?”

“Wait… I’ll check…”

I grabbed a handful of snow with my woollen gloves and squeezed it hard between my hands. When I released the grip, the ball remained intact.

Good news: it wasn’t powder.

I turned back to Binti, pretended to point out a squirrel in the tree and, when her back was turned, I threw my snowball right at her back!

“Ice ball missile incoming! Ha ha ha!”



Binti wasn’t happy and threatened to tell Oummi if I didn’t stop. But as soon as my back was turned, she took a pile of snow in the palm of her hands and poured it right on my head!

The snow seeped through my scarf and slid all the way down my back, between my skin and my t-shirt.

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I wriggled around trying to get the snow to fall out of my clothes, because it was so cold.

“Ha ha. You look like a chicken ice-skating!”, said Binti.

Oummi was staring out of the kitchen window and waving her arms like crazy. I just knew she was going to have lots to say to us when we got back later.



On the way to school, we noticed several times how slippery the ground was. The problem was, with my boots on, I didn’t have much grip: I wasn’t used to walking in them yet. I didn’t look like a chicken, but more like a lame duck.

Fortunately, I wasn’t the only one in this situation at school. Me and my friends all had a good laugh when we noticed we were all wearing the same plastic boots on our feet!

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Abi had bought them from the same store as everyone else: Jeremy's father's.



That morning, the playground looked like a building site! All the children were scrambling to make the most beautiful snowman.

Some were quite talented...



Others, less so...



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The rest of us preferred a completely different kind of activity... something a little more ‘sporty’.

Anass came up with the idea and set the rules.

The challenge was to slide as far as possible, taking just three steps. Jeremy made a respectable first attempt, closely followed by Rachid.



But it was Anass who smashed the record!

He used some techniques he’d learnt at Taekwondo on the jump, then slid several metres with one hand resting on the ground.



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To overtake him, I was going to have to outdo myself. I warned my friends to keep a sharp lookout…

“Look out! I’m going to pull out my secret weapon!”

“You’re going to bring out a weapon? But that’s not allowed at school!” reacted Rachid.

“But no!” replied Jeremy. “A secret weapon means that he’s going to use a special technique that nobody knows but him.”

“Is that so? I’d like to see that,” challenged Anass.

I then took out of my rucksack the big brown leather folder that Abi had bought me at the start of the school year and took up my position.

3, 2, 1, go!

I ran at full speed and then, just as I was about to jump, I threw my folder to the ground, landing on it with both feet and sliding with it as if I were on a skateboard!

Incredibly, it worked! It even worked TOO well… it went TOO fast!



My friends were originally amazed when I zoomed past them. But when they realised that I had no control over my speed or my direction, they began to fear the worst.

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“WALAD! Hit the brakes! You’re going too fast!” exclaimed Rachid.

Yeah, well, I knew I was going too fast.

But what really worried me was where I was going to end up in my crazy race...



I did whatever I could to regain control of my folderboard, but nothing helped.

I hit the bench at full speed and ended up in the air, before landing two metres further on the slippery ground, adding three metres to the seemingly endless fall.



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The good news: I'd won the contest.

The bad news: I'd hurt my right thumb badly. Sure, my glove had cushioned the impact of my hand Al hamdoulilah, but my thumb had doubled in size.

"Wow. Does it hurt?" worried Anass.

"A little, but I can't really move it that well."



The school bell rang in the playground.

All the children, except me, lined up to go to their classrooms.

The headmaster had seen my stunt in the distance and hurried over to check on me. At the sight of my swollen thumb, he asked me to follow him to the first aid room.

On the way, away from my friends, I cried a little. It didn't really hurt, but I was afraid my parents would tell me off when they found out. I hadn't been careful, as Oummi had recommended.

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Besides... what was Abi going to say when he saw the state of the beautiful brown folder he'd bought me for English lessons.



At the first aid room, the nurse calmed me down my giving me a smiley face sticker. Then he took my thumb in his hands and began to turn it in all directions.

"You tell me as soon as it hurts."

"What do I say?"

"Well, you say 'Ouch', for example," he replied, smiling.



On the whole, it didn't hurt much. But he often asked me if I felt any pain, so every now and then I'd emit an 'Ouch'... to please him.

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After that, he took a spray out of a nearby cabinet and sprayed my thumb with a cold mist. I had to hold back my laughter as it tickled. Then he pulled out a long strip of bandage and wrapped it around my thumb.

"No big deal! You must have sprained something when you landed on your thumb. On the other hand, I don't think you'll be able to use it properly for at least a week."

"Oh, that's okay... a thumb's not much use anyway," I boasted confidently.

"Isn't it? Well, then! You might be surprised. All right, that's it. You can join your class now!"



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Wow. The nurse hadn't skimped on the thickness of the bandage. My thumb, which had already doubled in size after the shock, now looked completely out of proportion to my hand.

When I entered the classroom, my friends were at first surprised by my bandage. Then, when they saw the smile on my face, they started teasing me about the size of my thumb.

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“Walad, are you sure that’s not your foot in your bandage?” joked Jeremy in a low voice.

“You should put a hat on him so he doesn’t catch a cold out there,” added Rachid with a chuckle.



I didn’t hold it against them. It made me laugh too. But I was about to lose my smile...

As I tried to get my things out of my bag, I noticed that I was having trouble getting hold of the zip. It took me a good five minutes to open it with my left hand.

After that, I couldn’t write. That’s when I realised that the thumb was indispensable for holding a pen! I’d never noticed it before.

I tried a bit with my left hand, but it was it was a disaster. I was writing like a four-year-old. The teacher, seeing my handwriting, wasn’t very happy. He asked me to stop and make up the lesson later.

In any case, it was time to move on to physical activities.

Once a week, we had hands-on lessons in class. It was everyone’s favourite time. We could finally get out of our chairs and do fun things with our hands and imaginations.

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Today, it was time for pottery.
We formed small groups of four, then sat down at a table with clay, water and small wooden accessories.

Just as I was about to plunge my hands into the clay, Rachid stopped me dead in my tracks:

"Careful! Did you forget you had a bandage?!"

"Oh yes, I did. Hmm... what am I going to do?"

"Here, put a plastic bag around it so it doesn't get dirty – that's what I had to do when I had a plastercast on my foot last year," advised Anass.

It was handy for protecting the bandage, but it was clearly a handicap for making pottery!



After a few minutes, when my friends had had enough of me ruining the pottery we were to make together, I stepped back.

Alone, in my corner, I spent the rest of the morning watching my friends having fun building a superb castle, while I twiddled my thumbs... or rather a thumb.

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